

WORK-IN-PROGRESS SNEAK PREVIEW

LIONHEART

THE JOEL LOMNICK STORY

VOLUME 2

Reinvention, brotherhood, Richmond, and the unfinished work of becoming

The road after Rochester

A draft public preview

This ten-page edition introduces selected scenes and themes from the developing second volume. The manuscript remains in progress. Dates, names, sequence, and wording may continue to change as the full book is revised and verified.

Troy, Albany, and Schenectady: 2007-2014

Richmond, Virginia: 2014-July 2026

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Selected and condensed for public preview by the author.

This preview does not replace the final manuscript.

"I did not leave Rochester empty-handed. The ghosts packed themselves."

2007 - TROY, NEW YORK

The chrysalis

By 2007, Rochester had become both sanctuary and sarcophagus. I left with a new engineering job, a U-Haul full of mismatched furniture, and more grief than I knew how to name. Troy offered steep hills, cold mornings, and the dangerous promise that distance might become reinvention.

The apartment I shared with a close friend became part war room, part living museum. Books leaned against camera equipment. Candles burned beside vision boards. Gospel records, garlic fries, work complaints, and Black-boy therapy sessions filled the rooms. We were young men trying to become whole without admitting how badly we had been fractured.

During the day I learned corporate engineering: drawings, calculations, deadlines, microaggressions, and the quiet exhaustion of being the only Black engineer in the room. At night I wrote, prayed, argued, dreamed, and tried to understand what it meant to be a Black bisexual man building a professional life without a usable blueprint.

We were not simply sharing an apartment. We were trying to become people we had never seen modeled.

Grief learned to dance



Culture remained one of the places I returned to.

Albany taught me that grief could wear church clothes. I joined a historic Black congregation, sang, served, created programs, and learned how power moved through sanctuaries long before anyone admitted politics had entered the room.

My mother died in July 2008. One month later, a musician I had come to regard as a brother lost his mother too. Grief fused us together. I became a manager, promoter, strategist, and believer in his talent. We carried gospel into clubs, rehearsals, local stages, and every place where sacred and secular refused to stay separated.

Culture gave me another language. African drum and dance returned rhythm to a body that had become too accustomed to bracing for impact. Writing gave me characters bold enough to say what I still whispered. Albany did not make me peaceful. It made me rooted enough to keep becoming.

Brotherhood became work



Brotherhood, leadership, and the responsibility to leave something stronger.

In 2011, I entered Iota Phi Theta looking for brotherhood, tradition, and a place where Black men could challenge one another without pretending we were invulnerable. I found all of that - and the complicated responsibility that arrives when a title becomes work.

Fraternity life sharpened my leadership. It also gave me another place to code-switch. I could be the advisor, the strategist, the dependable brother, and still keep portions of my identity sealed behind a professional smile. Brotherhood became both a calling and a camouflage.

Years later, I would understand that the real measure of a chapter was not who could perform loyalty in public. It was who could build systems, protect younger men, tell the truth when it was inconvenient, and leave the organization stronger than they found it.

2014 - RICHMOND, VIRGINIA

The floor vanished

I arrived in Richmond in 2014 with a promised job, a U-Haul full of belongings, and a gas tank full of faith. Then the job disappeared. For six weeks, my car became bedroom, confessional, sanctuary, and war room. Planet Fitness became my bathroom. My retirement account became oxygen.

I told almost nobody. Pride can be a survival tool until it becomes another locked door. My younger brother helped me secure an apartment, and I repaid him with my first three checks. Then came a contract engineering position in Charlottesville, a punishing commute, low pay, and the first fragile evidence that the floor might hold again.

Richmond did not welcome me with a resurrection montage. It gave me traffic, rejection, grief, and work. Brick by brick, that was enough.

*My car became bedroom, confession booth,
sanctuary, and war room.*

A public excerpt from the Richmond arrival sequence

The rooms that gave me back to myself



The church balcony became a place where technology and ministry met.

Third Street Bethel AME Church gave me a balcony full of wires, cameras, microphones, and purpose. I learned that media ministry was not decoration. It was how the sick, the traveling, the grieving, and the curious remained connected to worship. Service could be technical and still be holy.

The dance floor gave me joy without requiring a speech. African drum and dance brought memory back into my body. Line dancing brought laughter, community, and the permission to move without making every movement a metaphor for pain.

Mentoring gave the work a future tense. Sitting with Black boys and young men, I recognized brilliance that often arrived disguised as silence, anger, humor, or uncertainty. I could not rewrite my childhood, but I could help somebody else enter adulthood with more language, preparation, and backup than I had.

The house inside me

Richmond gave me love - the kind that held a mirror up to my trauma and refused to admire only the polished parts. Relationships forced me to face the difference between being wanted and being safe, between loyalty and fear, between building a home and merely occupying one.

For years, I treated bisexuality like a private technical condition: real, consequential, and never to be discussed outside a controlled room. Healing required a different kind of honesty. I had to stop reducing myself so other people could remain comfortable.

I did not become fearless. I became less willing to abandon myself. That was a quieter victory than a promotion, a degree, or a public title - and one of the hardest things I ever built.

I did not become fearless. I became less willing to abandon myself.

2021-JULY 2026

The builder becomes visible



The work mattered most when someone else could grow from it.

By July 2026, the pieces of my life were no longer hidden in separate rooms. Engineering, Lomnick Professional Services, Lionheart, church media, Iota and NPHC leadership, mentoring, cultural arts, and the long pursuit of professional licensure had become one visible body of work.

I had spent years believing legitimacy would arrive when somebody handed me the right title. Instead, legitimacy came through repetition: showing up, documenting the work, repairing what failed, teaching what I had learned, and refusing to let survival be the most interesting thing about me.

The story is still unfinished. The PE examination, leadership transitions, family grief, health, love, money, and legacy remain active chapters. Volume 2 does not end with a man who has solved himself. It ends with a man who finally understands that becoming is not evidence of failure. It is the work.

JULY 2026 - THE STORY REMAINS OPEN

Still building. Still healing. Still becoming.

Volume 2 is not a victory lap. It is the record of a man learning that survival, success, service, intimacy, faith, and ambition do not resolve in a straight line. The full manuscript will carry the unfinished contradictions, hard-won humor, and July 2026 questions this preview can only introduce.

The road continues beyond the last page.

Lionheart: The Joel Lomnick Story

Volume 2 - work-in-progress preview

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